

Theatricality and Cinematic Space in Yoruba Epic Film: A Study of *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022)

Gbenga Emmanuel ADEBOYE

Department of Dramatic Arts

Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife, Nigeria

E-mail: geadeboye@oauife.edu.ng

ORCID ID: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-6324-0035>

Oyindamola Christiana SHITTU

Department of Performing Arts, Music and Film Studies,

Lead City University, Ibadan, Nigeria.

E-mail: shittudamola@gmail.com

Abstract

*This study examines how theatricality shapes cinematic space in Yoruba epic film, with focus on *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022). The problem addressed is the limited scholarly attention given to how Nollywood epic films organise space, movement, ritual action, spectacle, costume, gesture, and ensemble coordination through theatrical principles. Existing studies often treat Yoruba films mainly as cultural, historical, or adaptation texts, with less attention to their stage-derived methods of screen construction. The study aims to analyse how theatrical codes are translated into film language, and to identify how blocking, spatial arrangement, ritual procession, combat choreography, and visual design produce meaning. It adopts Lars Elleström's theory of intermediality, especially his 2021 formulation on media borders and transformation, because it explains how one artistic medium transfers, reshapes, and refunctions materials within another. Using qualitative performance analysis, the paper argues that the selected films do not merely reproduce Yoruba performance culture, they reorganise it through cinematic framing, editing, and spatial composition. The study contributes to African film scholarship and performance studies research by showing how indigenous performance systems inform screen aesthetics, cultural memory, and contemporary spectatorship.*

Keywords: Yoruba epic film, theatricality, cinematic space, intermediality, Nollywood.

Introduction

Contemporary Yoruba epic cinema occupies an important position within African screen culture because of its ability to translate indigenous performance traditions into technologically mediated visual forms. Increasing investments in historical reconstruction, ritual representation, choreographed spectacle, large-scale visual composition, digital production, and global streaming distribution have expanded the formal possibilities and international visibility of contemporary Yoruba epic filmmaking. Despite these developments, studies on Yoruba film have largely concentrated on representation, adaptation, nationalism, identity formation, and indigenous epistemologies, with comparatively limited attention given to how theatrical principles organise cinematic space. The historical development of Yoruba cinema demonstrates that theatre and film emerged through interconnected rather than separate

aesthetic traditions. Yoruba-language filmmaking developed from earlier traditions of itinerant theatre, ritual enactment, masquerade performance, oral aesthetics, and popular entertainment cultures (Adedeji, 2014; Barber, 2000). The travelling theatre movement associated with practitioners such as Hubert Ogunde, Kola Ogunmola, and Duro Ladipo established aesthetic conventions that migrated into film production and created enduring continuities between stage and screen practices (Haynes, 2016). Consequently, theatricality within Yoruba cinema functions not simply as historical inheritance but as an active principle shaping visual organisation, bodily movement, spatial composition, and performance structure.

The importance of theatricality becomes more evident within epic filmmaking because epic narratives depend upon spectacle, collective performance, ritual enactment, and the organisation of bodies within structured visual environments. Cinematic space within epic film extends beyond physical location or scenic background; space functions as a representational system through which political authority, social hierarchy, ritual practice, memory, and cultural meaning become visible. Film theorists increasingly conceptualise cinematic space as a constructed phenomenon produced through framing, *mise-en-scène*, editing, movement, sound, and performance rather than as a neutral narrative container (Bordwell & Thompson, 2019; Bruno, 2002). Such considerations are particularly important within Yoruba cultural systems where space possesses social, ritual, and metaphysical significance. Sacred groves, shrines, palace courtyards, marketplaces, battlefields, riversides, and ritual pathways function simultaneously as physical and symbolic spaces through which relationships between human, ancestral, and spiritual domains are negotiated. Traditional Yoruba performance cultures organised these spaces through ritual movement, procession, music, costume systems, embodiment, and communal participation (Barber, 1997; Drewal & Drewal, 1983). When translated into cinematic environments, these spatial arrangements generate screen spaces shaped simultaneously by theatrical, ritual, and cinematic conventions.

Theatricality provides an important framework for examining these processes because theatricality extends beyond questions of stage influence. Performance theorists define theatricality through systems of display, visual organisation, embodiment, spectacle, and spatial arrangement that structure meaning within representational forms (Carlson, 2004; Pavis, 1998). Within cinema, theatricality becomes visible through choreographed movement, ritual gesture, ensemble composition, blocking patterns, costume display, and spatial organisation that foreground performance as a structuring mechanism. Theatre and cinema therefore function less as opposing forms than as interconnected representational systems characterised by continuous exchange and transformation.

Although existing scholarship has made significant contributions to understanding Yoruba cinema through the lenses of adaptation, cultural representation, nationalism, indigenous epistemologies, and historical reconstruction, comparatively little attention has been paid to the ways theatrical principles actively organise cinematic space as an aesthetic system. Much of the literature treats theatrical elements as inherited cultural features or evidence of the historical relationship between theatre and film rather than as formal mechanisms that structure visual meaning on screen. Consequently, insufficient attention has been given to how blocking, ensemble movement, ritual choreography, spatial hierarchy, *mise-en-scène*, and performance composition are transformed through cinematic techniques to produce specifically filmic experiences. By foregrounding theatricality as an organising principle of cinematic space rather

than merely a cultural residue or adaptive strategy, this study extends existing scholarship beyond adaptation and cultural analysis to demonstrate how indigenous performance systems are reconfigured through cinematic language. In doing so, it contributes a new intermedial perspective to contemporary Yoruba epic cinema by showing that theatricality functions not simply as inherited performance tradition but as an active aesthetic framework through which cinematic space, visual spectacle, and spectatorship are constructed.

This study examines these processes through an analysis of *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022). Both films foreground ritual action, collective embodiment, costume spectacle, and spatial organisation while simultaneously employing contemporary cinematic technologies to construct expansive visual environments. Whereas *Jagun Jagun* privileges militarised spectacle, combat choreography, and landscape composition, *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* foregrounds ceremonial movement, symbolic architecture, ritual performance, and metaphysical spatiality. The study adopts Lars Elleström's theory of intermediality, particularly the formulations concerning media transformation and media borders, because intermediality provides conceptual tools for examining how artistic materials migrate between media forms and acquire altered functions through processes of reconfiguration (Elleström, 2021). This framework is particularly useful because theatrical structures originating from ritual performance, oral traditions, masquerade practices, and stage conventions are reorganised through framing, editing, camera movement, sound design, and visual composition. Theatricality within Yoruba epic cinema therefore constitutes not merely continuity but intermedial transformation.

This study argues that *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022) transform indigenous performance systems into cinematic spatial strategies through which spectacle, ritual, authority, memory, and cultural identity become visually organised. By examining these processes, the study contributes to African film studies, performance studies, and intermedial research through an examination of how theatrical principles shape cinematic space within contemporary Yoruba epic film.

Theatricality, Cinematic Space, and Intermedial Construction in Yoruba Epic Film

Yoruba film production emerges from a sustained convergence of indigenous performance systems, ritual practice, oral aesthetics, masquerade traditions, and popular theatre cultures. Rather than developing independently of theatrical traditions, Yoruba cinema evolved through the adaptation and transformation of performance practices that had long structured communal entertainment, ritual expression, and cultural memory. The evolution of Nigerian screen production, therefore, cannot be separated from earlier Yoruba popular theatre, where performance functioned as a composite of music, dance, narration, spectacle, improvisation, and ritualised enactment. Etherton (1982) identifies Yoruba popular theatre as a form of communal performance structured through embodied action and collective participation, in which spatial arrangement functions as an active principle of meaning production rather than a passive container for dramatic action. Within this performative tradition, movement, procession, and ensemble coordination become primary communicative devices through which social hierarchy, ritual significance, and visual meaning are organised.

Contemporary developments have further complicated this relationship between tradition and

screen practice. Although digital technologies and streaming platforms have expanded the visibility and circulation of Yoruba films, scholars argue that these developments have also intensified debates about cultural authenticity and hybridity. As Osundiran and Akinsola (2025) observe:

Yorùbá films have developed over time owing to westernisation and technological advancements. Contemporary Yorùbá films are easily accessible through the internet and social media. However, the cultural contents of these films remain questionable due to influences from the Western world. Studies have identified the portrayal of Yorùbá culture, history, and folklore in Yorùbá films with less emphasis on how contemporary Yorùbá films have hybridised various cultures and possibly marginalised Yorùbá culture (Osundiran & Akinsola, 2025, p. 96).

While this scholarship highlights questions of cultural representation, hybridity, and identity, it pays comparatively less attention to how indigenous performance conventions continue to shape the formal organisation of cinematic space. This article extends that conversation by examining theatricality not merely as a cultural inheritance but as an aesthetic principle that structures visual composition, movement, and spectatorship within contemporary Yoruba epic cinema.

The transition from stage performance to screen production did not dissolve these aesthetic systems; instead, it reconfigured them within new technological environments. Ogunleye (2003) observes that Nigerian video film inherited expressive elements from Yoruba popular theatre, particularly costume articulation, oral performance structures, ritual display, and dramatic confrontation. Barber (2000) likewise demonstrates that Yoruba performance culture operates through fluid movement across media boundaries, where theatre, ritual, and popular entertainment share overlapping representational strategies. Similarly, Ukah (2003) argues that African popular media integrate ritual symbolism with modern visual technologies in ways that preserve indigenous semiotic systems within contemporary media environments. Collectively, these studies demonstrate that Yoruba cinema developed through the transformation and reorganisation of performance traditions rather than through a decisive break from them. Consequently, contemporary Yoruba epic cinema should be understood as the latest stage in a continuous process of intermedial exchange between indigenous performance and screen culture.

This historical continuity is further illustrated by Odugbemi's (2025) account of the movement of Yoruba travelling theatre into television and later film production. As he explains:

Following the introduction of television in Nigeria, Yoruba travelling theatre practitioners adopted it as a platform for exhibiting their performances. The Western Nigerian Broadcasting Service/Western Nigeria Television screened Hubert Ogunde's plays, and subsequent policies encouraged more theatre practitioners to produce for television. This transition continued through celluloid filmmaking and later video-film production, ultimately contributing to the emergence of the Nigerian epic film genre (Odugbemi, 2025, pp. 75–76).

Odugbemi's account demonstrates that Yoruba epic cinema emerged through successive technological transformations rather than through the replacement of theatrical practice. As performance traditions migrated from live theatre to television and eventually to cinema, their aesthetic principles were continually reconfigured to accommodate the expressive possibilities of each new medium.

The concept of theatricality provides a critical framework for understanding these continuities. Burns (1972) defines theatricality as representation structured through display, visibility, and organised presentation that extends beyond the physical stage into broader visual culture. Postlewait and Davis (2003) similarly conceptualise theatricality as the arrangement of embodied action and visual signs through which meaning becomes spatially and visually legible to spectators. Within film studies, Elsaesser and Buckland (2002) argue that theatricality emerges through intensified visual composition, choreographed movement, and controlled performance, while Kozloff (2000) demonstrates that performance-centred cinema preserves theatrical organisation through dialogue, bodily orientation, and spatial concentration within the cinematic frame. These perspectives suggest that theatricality should not be understood as evidence of cinema's dependence on theatre but as a distinct aesthetic strategy through which performance structures cinematic meaning. In Yoruba epic film, theatricality is manifested through ritual choreography, ensemble staging, costume hierarchy, blocking, and ceremonial spectacle, all of which contribute to the construction of cinematic space.

Cinematic space constitutes another foundational axis of this study because epic filmmaking depends upon the organisation of environments that communicate political authority, ritual order, and collective identity. Branigan (1984) argues that cinematic space emerges through the spectator's structured orientation rather than through physical geography alone, while Monaco (2009) identifies framing, editing, camera movement, and *mise-en-scène* as the principal mechanisms through which cinema constructs spatial meaning. Likewise, Aumont (2017) rejects spatial naturalism by insisting that cinematic space is produced through visual arrangement and compositional design. These perspectives underscore that space in cinema is not merely a backdrop but an active aesthetic construction that organises narrative, performance, and spectatorship.

Within Yoruba cultural systems, spatial organisation assumes additional significance because physical and metaphysical environments are conceived as interconnected domains. Thompson (1974) identifies processional movement and symbolic occupation of space as defining features of Yoruba expressive culture, while Beier (1980) demonstrates that masquerade and festival traditions organise spectatorship through structured visibility, ceremonial sequencing, and collective participation. Abiodun (2014) further argues that Yoruba visual culture produces meaning through the interaction of bodily presence, sacred symbolism, and spatial arrangement. Consequently, palaces, shrines, forests, battlefields, and ritual pathways in Yoruba epic cinema function not merely as settings but as symbolic environments through which authority, spirituality, memory, and social order are visually articulated.

African film scholarship further reinforces these spatial concerns by emphasising cultural memory, symbolic organisation, and communal modes of representation. Diawara (1992) identifies African cinema as a site where historical representation intersects with ritual practice and symbolic spatial coding, while Pfaff (2004) argues that African filmmakers frequently

organise cinematic environments according to ceremonial and communal logics rather than strict naturalism. More recent scholarship on contemporary Nollywood similarly observes that digital production technologies, streaming platforms, and transnational distribution have expanded the visual scale and aesthetic ambitions of African filmmaking without necessarily displacing indigenous performance traditions. Within contemporary Yoruba epic cinema, therefore, spatial organisation simultaneously reflects local performance cultures and evolving cinematic practices, making it particularly productive for an intermedial analysis of theatricality and cinematic space.

Intermediality provides an additional analytical framework for understanding the movement of theatrical structures into cinematic form. Chapple and Kattenbelt (2006) define intermediality as interaction between media systems that produces transformed representational configurations, while Müller (2010) argues that intermedial processes emerge when expressive materials migrate across media boundaries and acquire altered functions. Bolter and Grusin (1999) conceptualise this transformation as remediation, whereby earlier representational systems are reorganised through new technological conditions. Within Yoruba epic cinema, ritual choreography, oral performance, masquerade traditions, costume systems, and ceremonial movement are reconfigured through cinematography, editing, sound design, and digital visualisation. Hutcheon (2006) reinforces this position by defining adaptation as creative transformation shaped by medium-specific operations rather than reproduction.

Contemporary Nollywood production intensifies these intermedial and spatial concerns through an increasing emphasis on spectacle, scale, and visual elaboration. Adejunmobi (2007) identifies visual display and technological enhancement as central to the negotiation of local cultural materials within global screen circulation, while Garritano (2013) associates digital filmmaking practices with expanded visual composition, movement, and spectacle-driven aesthetics. Within Yoruba epic cinema, these tendencies appear through battle choreography, ritual procession, aerial cinematography, monumental architecture, costume hierarchies, and large-scale ensemble coordination.

Despite sustained engagement with Nollywood, African cinema, theatricality, and intermediality, insufficient attention has been given to the specific mechanisms through which theatrical organisation structures cinematic space within Yoruba epic film. Questions concerning blocking, ritual choreography, ensemble arrangement, spatial hierarchy, costume articulation, and ceremonial movement remain under-examined. This study addresses this gap through an analysis of *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022), focusing on how theatricality is reconfigured through cinematic spatial construction, visual composition, and intermedial transformation.

***Jagun Jagun* (2023): Narrative and Cinematic Construction**

Jagun Jagun (2023) is a Yoruba-language epic war film produced by Euphoria 360 Media and distributed by Netflix. Directed by Tope Adebayo and Adebayo Tijani, the film exemplifies the contemporary evolution of Yoruba epic cinema through its large-scale production design, choreographed combat sequences, ensemble performance, and integration of indigenous theatrical traditions with digital filmmaking. Produced by and starring Femi Adebayo, the film continues the performance legacy of the Yoruba travelling theatre, particularly the tradition

associated with Adebayo Salami (Oga Bello).

The narrative is framed through oral storytelling by Jimi Solanke and centres on the struggle for power within a militarised Yoruba kingdom. Ogundiji (Femi Adebayo), a formidable warlord, establishes a military academy where warriors are trained under a rigid hierarchical system (see Figure 1). Gbotija (Lateef Adedimeji), an exceptionally gifted recruit, gradually emerges as his principal rival, while Iroyinogunkitan (Bukunmi Oluwasina), later transformed into Agemo, embodies the intersection of personal loyalty, political strategy, and institutional power. The narrative culminates in the defeat of Ogundiji, signalling the collapse of authoritarian rule and the reconfiguration of political authority.



Figure 1. Ogundiji (Femi Adebayo), a formidable warlord and Gbotija (Lateef Adedimeji), an exceptionally gifted recruit.

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f0YiviYRnvU>

Beyond its narrative, the film constructs meaning through carefully organised cinematic space. The military academy, palace, forest, and battlefield function as distinct spatial environments that articulate discipline, governance, ritual, and conflict. Costume design reinforces military and political hierarchy through differentiated fabrics, armour, colour schemes, and symbolic motifs, while coordinated ensemble movement reflects the collective performance traditions of Yoruba theatre. The film's visual style further enhances this theatrical organisation. Wide framing, aerial cinematography, controlled camera movement, and rhythmic editing preserve the visibility of group formations and large-scale action. Lighting differentiates ceremonial, military, and nocturnal spaces, while percussion, chants, and oral narration reinforce movement, ritual, and spatial coordination. These cinematic elements transform indigenous performance practices into a visually expansive screen aesthetic. Rather than merely adapting Yoruba cultural traditions, *Jagun Jagun* reconfigures them through contemporary cinematic techniques. Its integration of theatrical performance, choreographed spectacle, and digital cinematography demonstrates how indigenous performance systems continue to shape the visual language of contemporary Yoruba epic cinema while expanding their expressive possibilities through film.

Theatricality and Cinematic Space in *Jagun Jagun* (2023)

Spatial organisation in *Jagun Jagun* (2023) is constructed through deliberate arrangement of human presence, coordinated movement, and hierarchical positioning within defined environments. Space functions not as passive background but as an active system through which authority, discipline, and resistance are visually articulated. Postlewait and Davis (2003) describe theatricality as a mode of representation structured through arranged visibility within a controlled field of action. This formulation provides a direct basis for understanding spatial construction in the film, where meaning is generated through structured placement rather than narrative explanation alone. Spatial meaning is established through staging, understood as the deliberate arrangement of performers and coordinated movement within defined environments. Across all major locations in the film, staging governs how authority and hierarchy are visually communicated. Characters are positioned in ways that immediately indicate rank, control, submission, or opposition.

The military academy presents the clearest articulation of structured spatial organisation. The academy operates as a regulated training environment where recruits are arranged in ordered formations that include rows, lines, and coordinated group configurations. Movement is executed through synchronised patterns that suppress individual variation in favour of collective alignment. Carlson (2004) associates theatricality with structured visibility that prioritises arrangement over spontaneity. In the academy sequences, authority is communicated through repetition, alignment, and regulated movement patterns that sustain institutional discipline.

The battlefield extends this system into open spatial conditions. Combat is presented through structured group confrontation rather than fragmented individual conflict. Opposing forces enter, advance, and withdraw in coordinated formations that preserve spatial legibility. Elsaesser and Buckland (2002) argue that theatrical organisation in film emerges when movement is structured for visual clarity. Battlefield sequences follow this principle by maintaining formation integrity during confrontation, ensuring that spatial order is preserved even during conflict.

Palace environments operate through hierarchical spatial arrangement. Authority is communicated through positioning within the frame, where central placement indicates command authority and peripheral positioning indicates subordinate roles. Seating order, entrance sequencing, and proximity to ruling figures function as indicators of political structure. Aumont (2017) notes that cinematic space is constructed through visual organisation rather than geographical imitation. Palace sequences demonstrate this principle through controlled placement that communicates authority through spatial relation.

Forest and ritual environments reduce spatial complexity and concentrate attention on gesture, chant, and symbolic action. Movement is limited and structured around specific ceremonial actions rather than continuous circulation. Abiodun (2014) explains that Yoruba visual systems organise meaning through the relationship between symbolic material, action, and spatial arrangement. These sequences demonstrate meaning formation through controlled interaction between movement and environment rather than dialogue expansion.

Camera organisation reinforces spatial structure through framing and perspective control. Wide framing preserves group formations within a single visual field, ensuring that spatial relationships remain visible. Elevated camera positions are used in large-scale sequences to present coordinated formations across terrain. Branigan (1984) explains that framing determines how space is perceived and organised within cinema. In *Jagun Jagun*, framing sustains visibility of structured group arrangements across all environments. Editing maintains separation between distinct spatial zones while preserving narrative continuity. Movement between academy, palace, battlefield, and ritual spaces follows a structured sequence that maintains functional distinction while ensuring narrative coherence. Monaco (2009) notes that editing constructs relationships between spatial units. The film uses editing to maintain environmental distinction while linking them within a unified narrative system.

Group organisation remains the foundation of spatial construction across all environments. Characters appear consistently within structured collectives such as trainees, warriors, commanders, and attendants. These groups function as units of spatial meaning that determine how environments are interpreted. Beier (1980) identifies group coordination as a structural principle in Yoruba performance organisation. The film transfers this principle into cinematic form, where collective arrangement determines spatial intelligibility. Elleström's (2021) intermedial framework explains this transformation as a process of structured transfer between media systems. Performance-based principles of spatial arrangement, group coordination, and ceremonial organisation are reconfigured through cinematic mechanisms such as framing, editing, and camera movement. The film demonstrates how performance structures are not directly reproduced but reorganised through technical cinematic conditions. *Jagun Jagun* constructs cinematic space as an ordered system in which meaning emerges through arrangement, movement coordination, and controlled visibility. Across all environments, spatial organisation functions as the primary mechanism through which authority, resistance, and transformation are expressed within contemporary Yoruba epic cinema.

Synopsis of *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022)

Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman (2022), directed by Biyi Bandele, is a Yoruba-language historical drama adapted from Wole Soyinka's play *Death and the King's Horseman*. The film is set in the Oyo Kingdom during British colonial administration and centres on a ritual obligation that governs continuity between the living world and the ancestral realm. Within this worldview, the death of the Alaafin requires his horseman, Elesin Oba (Odunlade Adekola), to undergo a ritual transition that ensures equilibrium between both realms. The narrative frames this duty as a collective responsibility embedded within cultural continuity rather than an individual moral choice. Elesin's movement toward this obligation is disrupted by attachment to immediate pleasure and personal desire. On the eve of his transition, he enters a marriage arrangement that delays his ritual responsibility. This hesitation produces disorder within the expected ceremonial sequence. The disruption intensifies when Simon Pilkings, the British colonial officer, intervenes after interpreting the ritual as unacceptable cultural practice. His decision to detain Elesin prevents completion of the ritual process and interrupts the continuity expected by the community.

Olunde (Deyemi Okanlawon), Elesin's son, returns from medical training in England and encounters a fractured ceremonial order. Although educated within Western medical systems,

he remains committed to Yoruba ritual responsibility. His decision to assume the role abandoned by his father restores continuity through substitution. His death repositions responsibility within intergenerational structure rather than individual authority. Following Olunde's action, Elesin confronts the consequence of failure, leading to his final withdrawal from life. The narrative closes with rupture in ceremonial continuity, presenting a community destabilised by both colonial intervention and personal interruption of duty.

Analysis of Cinematic Translation of Theatrical Codes in *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022)

The film constructs meaning through systematic transformation of stage-based performance structures into cinematic form. The dramatic source depends on spoken exchange, ceremonial presence, and spatial organisation within live performance conditions. The film translates these elements through visual framing, movement arrangement, and spatial composition while maintaining the structural discipline of Yoruba performance systems. A central transformation occurs in the organisation of movement within space. Stage performance relies on coordinated positioning to express hierarchy, relational order, and ritual progression. The film preserves this structure through carefully arranged group formations in public ceremonial spaces. Elesin consistently occupies central spatial positions that affirm his role as the axis of ritual expectation. Surrounding groups, including drummers, market participants, and attendants, form circular and linear configurations that sustain collective rhythm during ceremonial sequences. Wide framing is used to preserve these formations, ensuring that spatial relations remain intact.



Figure 2. Elesin (Odunlade Adekola) dancing with his praise singer in the market place.

Source: <https://medium.com/@kosokooyeyemi/elesin-oba-a-stunning-film-that-never-quite-comes-alive-216dceedd54d>

Spatial contrast is employed to distinguish cultural systems (see Figure 2). Yoruba communal environments are represented through open settings such as markets, courtyards, and procession routes, where collective presence governs movement. Colonial environments are constructed

through enclosed architectural structures defined by restricted movement and rigid alignment. This contrast produces a visual separation between communal circulation and administrative containment.

Lighting design contributes to spatial meaning. Natural illumination dominates communal scenes, especially in market environments where sunlight interacts with collective activity. This reinforces openness and shared visibility. Colonial scenes rely on reduced illumination and shadowed composition, producing controlled visual fields that limit interaction and emphasise separation. Costume and visual design operate as markers of social position. Elesin's attire reflects ceremonial authority within Yoruba governance structures. Iyalaja's clothing communicates stabilising authority within communal order. Villagers' attire maintains continuity with shared cultural identity. Colonial characters appear in rigid uniform design that visually separates them from indigenous spatial organisation.

Sound design functions as an organising structure for movement and rhythm. Yoruba performance tradition integrates speech, drumming, chanting, and song as part of its structural organisation. The film maintains this system through layered sound arrangements that regulate ceremonial pacing. Drumming structures movement timing, chant reinforces collective participation, and praise forms establish narrative continuity. Silence functions as a marker of disruption during interrupted ceremonial sequences. Ritual procession operates as a primary mechanism of theatrical translation into film form. Processional movement structures transition between social and metaphysical states. The film presents procession as a coordinated system governed by rhythm, spatial order, and collective participation. Extended tracking shots maintain continuity of movement, while editing follows rhythmic progression rather than abrupt segmentation. The breakdown of procession marks a shift in spatial organisation. As Elesin's commitment weakens, coordinated movement loses structure. Colonial intervention interrupts continuity, replacing ordered circulation with fragmented motion. This transition signals the collapse of ritual order into disrupted spatial formation.

Dance sequences extend structured movement into expressive form. Dance operates as organised movement embedded within ceremonial progression. The film integrates dance through coordinated group formation aligned with musical rhythm. Camera movement follows motion patterns, allowing visual continuity between performer and space. The theoretical foundation of these transformations aligns with Lars Elleström's intermedial framework, particularly his model of media transformation through transfer and reorganisation of expressive material across distinct media systems. The film demonstrates how stage performance structures are not reproduced directly but reconfigured through cinematic mechanisms such as framing, editing, and audiovisual coordination.

Comparative Analysis of *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022)

Although *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022) employ different narrative trajectories, both demonstrate how theatricality functions as a fundamental principle in the construction of cinematic space. Each film draws upon Yoruba performance traditions through choreographed movement, ritualised action, ensemble staging, costume symbolism, and structured spatial organisation. Rather than reproducing theatrical performance directly, both films transform these performative conventions through cinematic techniques such as

framing, editing, camera movement, sound design, and mise-en-scène, thereby exemplifying Elleström's notion of intermedial transformation.

The two films differ, however, in their spatial and aesthetic priorities. *Jagun Jagun* constructs cinematic space through expansive landscapes, military formations, combat choreography, and dynamic camera movement that foreground spectacle, power, and territorial authority. Its visual language privileges movement across open spaces, using wide shots, aerial cinematography, and rhythmic editing to reinforce collective action and martial discipline. In contrast, *Elesin Oba* organises cinematic space around ritual processions, ceremonial architecture, and symbolic environments. Its restrained pacing, measured camera movements, and emphasis on spatial intimacy foreground metaphysical order, communal responsibility, and ritual continuity rather than physical conquest.

Despite these differences, both films demonstrate that cinematic space in contemporary Yoruba epic cinema is produced through the interaction of theatrical organisation and film-specific aesthetics. Spatial hierarchy, bodily movement, costume, performance, and ritual remain rooted in indigenous theatrical traditions, yet their expressive functions are expanded through cinematic technologies that reshape spectatorship and visual experience. Consequently, *Jagun Jagun* and *Elesin Oba* illustrate complementary models of contemporary Yoruba epic filmmaking: the former privileges theatrical spectacle as the basis of cinematic action, while the latter transforms theatrical ritual into a visually mediated exploration of cultural memory and metaphysical order. Together, they confirm that theatricality is not merely a historical inheritance but a dynamic aesthetic framework through which contemporary Yoruba epic cinema constructs meaning.

Conclusion

This study examined how theatricality shapes cinematic space in *Jagun Jagun* (2023) and *Elesin Oba: The King's Horseman* (2022) through the organisation of movement, spatial arrangement, ritual performance, combat presentation, costume design, sound, and visual composition. The analysis demonstrates that both films construct meaning not only through narrative progression but through deliberate spatial organisation derived from Yoruba performance traditions and restructured through cinematic techniques. Using Elleström's intermediality theory, the study established that these films do not merely transfer theatrical materials into cinema but reorganise them through framing, editing, camera movement, location design, and visual composition. Ritual procession, ensemble arrangement, choreographed action, and ceremonial organisation are transformed into cinematic forms while maintaining their performative functions. The study therefore argues that contemporary Yoruba epic cinema should not be approached solely as historical representation, adaptation, or cultural expression, but also as a spatial practice in which theatrical principles remain central to cinematic construction. By demonstrating how indigenous performance systems continue to shape screen aesthetics, the study contributes to broader discussions within African film studies, performance studies, and intermedial research.

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Notes on Contributors

Gbenga Emmanuel Adeboye is a theatre practitioner and lecturer in the Department of Dramatic Arts, Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife, Nigeria. His research interests include stage management, theatre pedagogy, production studies, archival documentation, sustainability in theatre practice, and African performance studies.

Shittu Oyindamola Christiana is a postgraduate student in the Department of Theatre and Film Studies at Redeemer's University, Ede, Nigeria. She specialises in Film Studies, with research interests in Film Criticism, Media Representation and Screen Culture.

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